Shop Build #1: The Rope End Table

Folks walk past this table in my living room and ask where I bought it. I made it out of a plain trash can, a coil of rough rope, and a round of wood somebody else threw away. Total damage: about three dollars if you shop like I do. Here is exactly how, start to finish. — Walt

What you need

- One plain metal or plastic trash can, 12–16 inches tall, straight sides (thrift store: about $1)
- Coarse braided rope, 30–40 feet — sisal or jute, 3/8 inch thick
- A round of wood for the top: a pine round, an old stool seat, or a cut-off tabletop — 2 inches wider than the mouth of the can
- Wood stain (any dark color) and a rag
- Hot glue gun and plenty of sticks — or construction adhesive for a forever hold
- Sandpaper, 120 grit
- Optional: felt pads for the bottom

The build

1. Clean the can. Wash it and dry it fully. Glue will not hold to dust or grease — that is where most of these projects fail, right at the start.

2. Start at the BOTTOM. Run a bead of glue around the can about half an inch up from the base. Press the end of the rope into it and start wrapping — tight, coil against coil, no gaps.

3. Work up in a spiral. A bead of glue every inch or so is plenty: dot the can, press the rope in, keep the tension. It should look wound, not glued — the glue is just the anchor.

4. At the rim, cut the rope on an angle and glue the tail flat so it disappears into the coil below it.

5. Sand the wood round smooth, edges too — that is where hands land. Wipe it clean.

6. Stain it: rag on, wait five minutes, rag off. Want it darker? Do it again. Let it dry a full hour.

7. Flip the can upside down — the bottom is now the table base, the flat stable end. Run a thick ring of glue or construction adhesive around it.

8. Center the wood round on top, press down hard, and set something heavy on it for ten minutes. Eyeball it from two sides before it sets.

9. Felt pads on the rim if it is going on a wood floor. Done.

Walt's notes

- Rope too fuzzy? Run a lighter along it quick — burns the whiskers off. Do not linger.
- Thrift stores price trash cans like trash. That is the whole trick: buy what other people undervalue.
- Outdoor version for the porch: construction adhesive instead of hot glue, and seal the wood.
- Same thinking, applied to a paycheck: The Briggs Budget System is at

sovereigndevelopers.org.